

The Way

THE GOSPEL WAS NEVER MEANT TO FIT INTO
FIFTEEN SECONDS

In a world where likes seem to matter more than truth, and where faith can become a product, this book challenges the promises of perfection, wealth, and lasting happiness, inviting us to return to the reality of Jesus.



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Introduction

I wrote this book with the purpose of sharing useful experiences and insights, grounded in the teachings of Jesus, as well as in the writings and scholarship of Doctors of the Catholic Church. It does not matter whether you are Catholic, because many people who are not Catholic nevertheless respect the work and scholarship of Doctors of the Church such as Saint Thomas Aquinas and Saint Augustine.

Today, there are *coaches* for virtually everything on the internet: *faith coaches*, nutrition coaches, relationship coaches, weight-loss coaches, and, in short, coaches for almost anything one can imagine. Yet many of them have distorted concepts and information in order to influence their thousands of followers, gain “likes,” and ultimately sell e-books, video courses, training programs, and other products, thereby making money and gaining fame.

They tell people what they want to hear, distorting reality and leading their followers to perceive their fallacies as absolute truths.

Social media can be extremely useful in many areas of knowledge and can be excellent learning tools. Yet in many cases, they have also become something of a jungle, where ravenous wolves stalk their prey in order to spread teachings that blend Christianity with nutrition, spirituality with wealth, and religion with all manner of unrelated subjects. In an effort to attract followers, some people try to bring Jesus—or concepts related to spirituality—into virtually every subject imaginable.

It is common to find stories on social media about relationships that have ended because one of the people involved followed the advice of an “influencer” who taught that, in a romantic relationship, both partners must be happy twenty-four hours a day, seven days a week; otherwise, the person is supposedly in a toxic relationship.

Others claim that if parents did not give their children a perfect childhood, like the ones portrayed in Hollywood movies, or if they ever behaved imperfectly, then they are toxic parents.

Some financial *coaches*, meanwhile, start from the premise that if you are not rich or a millionaire, you are not following Jesus correctly. According to this way of thinking, you would be committing terrible sins, because they equate every form of material wealth—regardless of the means by which it was acquired—with blessings from Heaven. Consequently, any life that does not involve wealth, luxury, and ostentation supposedly makes a person a failure.

They therefore preach a perfection that has never existed and never will in human history, leaving people frustrated because they cannot attain a supposedly perfect life in every respect.

These are precisely the issues this book seeks to explore. Not with the intention of presenting perfect human beings, perfect families, perfect relationships, or a life free from difficulties, but rather of showing that human reality is far more complex than the simplistic narratives we encounter every day on social media.

The Christian life, like human existence itself, is not a promise of a life without difficulties. Rather, it is a journey in which we learn to face our limitations, acknowledge our mistakes, forgive, mature, and understand that not every form of suffering is the result of someone having wronged us.

Throughout these pages, I will seek to examine these questions in light of the teachings of Jesus and the reflections of great thinkers in the Christian tradition, while never losing sight of the difficulties and contradictions of real life.

Childhood and Adolescence

Some people may have fond memories of their childhood and adolescence and tend to remember, for the most part, the good times, although that does not mean they do not also remember difficult experiences. Others, however, may forget the good moments and focus primarily on painful experiences.

Yet life has always been marked by some challenges, and often by many. Those who were born into families with limited resources may remember the frustration of not being able to have the latest sneakers, a video game console, or a bicycle. Some may even remember times when there was not enough food to eat. Those born into families with a reasonably stable financial situation faced different kinds of difficulties. Those who grew up in middle-class, upper-middle-class, or more affluent families may, in turn, remember trips to Disneyland Paris or other places considered extraordinary.

Not everyone has had, or has, the same opportunities in life. Some are born into comfortable families; others into families that barely have enough to survive. There are also those who are abandoned in orphanages, those who live on the streets because their parents struggle with drug addiction, and those who are born in war zones. Each person faces different challenges during this stage of life. In the future, some may use those experiences to become stronger and more grateful, while others may attribute every negative circumstance to someone else, usually their own parents.

I am not saying that children and adolescents who suffer abuse, such as severe physical or psychological violence, should simply turn those experiences into lessons. In such cases, the resulting trauma may require help from specialized healthcare professionals so that victims can overcome those experiences or learn to live with the wounds they have left behind.

The great problem is that some Internet “influencers,” on certain social media platforms, take ordinary childhoods and adolescences lived alongside ordinary parents—parents who are not perfect, because no human being is perfect—and begin classifying them according to behavioral patterns that, in their view, all parents should follow. In doing so, they end up placing those parents on the same level as violent parents who inflicted severe physical and psychological abuse on their own children, potentially leading children to see their parents as genuine enemies.

Then there are those who claim that parents are to blame for failing to provide their children with a comfortable life. According to this narrative, every parent should be wealthy before even considering having children. The premise behind these influencers’ message is that all parents should possess substantial material wealth while also being

perfect, in the sense that they must never make a single mistake, before thinking about starting a family.

This, obviously, is extremely utopian and impossible.

Imagine Joseph and Mary.

From the perspective of certain contemporary social-media narratives, they might well be considered a textbook example of “poor family planning.”

Mary became pregnant before she and Joseph had begun living together as husband and wife, in circumstances that, according to the social standards of their time, were certainly not easy. The Gospel of Matthew itself tells us that Joseph considered divorcing Mary quietly until he received divine guidance in a dream telling him to take her as his wife (Matthew 1:18–25).

Joseph, for his part, is not portrayed in the Gospels as a wealthy man. On the contrary, he is described as a *téktōn*, a term generally associated with a laborer or craftsman and traditionally translated as “carpenter” (Matthew 13:55). As the birth of Jesus approached, Joseph and Mary had to travel to Bethlehem because of the census ordered by the Roman authorities (Luke 2:1–5).

When they arrived, they found no comfortable place to stay. Jesus was born in extremely humble circumstances and was laid in a manger (Luke 2:6–7).

Today, social media would probably be filled with comments:

“How can anyone decide to have a child without first having a perfect home?”

“Where is the financial planning?”

“They did not even have a place to sleep, and they decided to bring a child into the world?”

“If they could not provide comfort, why did they have a child?”

“Joseph should have waited until he was in a better financial position.”

“Mary should have planned motherhood better.”

And depending on the influencer, there might even be a video claiming that Jesus was a victim of his parents’ “irresponsibility” because he was born into poverty.

Of course, there is a fundamental difference between recognizing the material difficulties a family faced and automatically accusing the parents of irresponsibility. Poverty, by itself, does not demonstrate neglect, just as wealth does not demonstrate competence as a parent.

Joseph and Mary could not provide Jesus with a childhood surrounded by luxury. They did not have a perfectly prepared nursery, expensive toys, international vacations, designer clothing, or all the experiences that can today be used as symbols of supposedly “good parenting.” Even so, it would be absurd to conclude that this family therefore lacked love, care, or dignity.

And here an important question arises: When did providing a materially perfect childhood become a requirement for someone to have the right to be a parent?

If this standard were applied absolutely, much of humanity would never have been able to start a family. Throughout virtually all of history, parents have raised their children without possessing what many people today consider indispensable: a home of their own, complete financial stability, an emergency fund, health insurance, a car, vacations, private education, sophisticated toys, and countless other possessions.

This does not mean that financial planning is useless. Quite the opposite. Adults should strive to provide their children with security, food, housing, education, protection, and decent conditions in which to grow and develop. It is also sensible to consider the responsibilities that come with the decision to have children.

The problem begins when what is reasonable becomes impossible: when parents are expected to have everything perfectly settled before starting a family, as though life could be planned without unexpected events, difficulties, or limitations.

Human existence itself is marked by unpredictability.

A family may begin with a certain financial situation and, years later, face unemployment. It may own a home and lose it because of a crisis. It may carefully plan a pregnancy only to discover that reality will be very different from what it imagined. It may live in a comfortable home and later be forced to move somewhere more modest. It may be able to afford certain things at one point in life and, at another, need to save even to cover basic necessities.

Being a parent does not come with a guarantee that everything will turn out well.

And, above all, being a child does not come with a guarantee that every desire will be fulfilled.

There is an enormous difference between a child being deprived of basic needs and simply not having everything the child wants.

Not having the latest sneakers is not necessarily neglect.

Not getting the newest video game console is not necessarily neglect.

Not going to Disneyland Paris is not necessarily neglect.

Not attending the most expensive school in the city is not necessarily neglect.

Not living in a luxurious home is not necessarily neglect.

Having parents who make mistakes does not automatically mean having abusive parents either.

Parents are human beings. They can make poor decisions, lose their patience, choose a career that later does not work out, mishandle some aspect of their lives, fail to immediately understand a particular need of their child, or simply lack the resources to provide something their child wants.

This is very different from violence, abuse, abandonment, or serious neglect.

A mature society must be capable of distinguishing between these situations.

If we place a child who suffered severe physical abuse on the same level as a child who was frustrated because his parents could not buy him the phone he wanted, we ultimately strip the word “abuse” of its meaning. Likewise, if we place parents who deliberately abuse their children on the same level as ordinary parents who made mistakes, we may end up creating a generation incapable of understanding the difference between an imperfect family relationship and a destructive one.

It is perfectly legitimate to acknowledge that our parents made mistakes.

It is also legitimate to acknowledge that some of their decisions caused us frustration.

We may even carry some of those frustrations with us for many years.

But there is a considerable distance between saying, “My parents made mistakes,” and concluding, “My parents destroyed my life.”

Between those two statements lies the full complexity of human experience.

Perhaps that is precisely what some of the simplified approaches found on social media fail to convey. In videos lasting only a few minutes, it is remarkably easy to turn a complex family history into a story of heroes and villains. The child is portrayed as the absolute victim, the parents as responsible for every difficulty, and any suffering experienced during childhood becomes evidence of some parental failure.

But life does not work like a three-minute video.

No one reaches adulthood carrying only what their parents did.

We also carry with us what happened to us, the historical circumstances into which we were born, our family's economic circumstances, the friends we had, the teachers we encountered, the opportunities that appeared—or failed to appear—our own decisions, our mistakes, our abilities and limitations, and an enormous number of events that no father or mother could possibly have controlled.

And perhaps we need to recover a rather simple idea: parents do not have to be perfect to be good parents.

They need to be human, responsible, loving, and willing, within their means, to care for their children.

Joseph and Mary could hardly be judged by the material standards of an affluent twenty-first-century family. Jesus was born without luxury, without comfort, and without the material conditions that many people would consider ideal.

Even so, turning that family's poverty into evidence of irresponsibility would be to confuse two entirely different things: not having much and failing to care.

A family can have very little and still offer love, protection, values, and dignity.

Another can have absolutely everything and offer its child money, gifts, and comfort, yet provide no affection, no boundaries, no presence, and no genuine care.

So perhaps the most important question is not: "How much were the parents able to provide for their children?"

Perhaps we should ask instead: "How did they treat their children with what they had?"

Because no one can give what they do not possess.

And demanding that everyone first have a perfect life before starting a family is imposing a condition that no human being could ever meet.

Jesus and a Life Without Guarantees of Comfort

There is another important aspect to consider when we think about Jesus' childhood and adolescence: the Gospels do not portray his earthly life as a story of material prosperity.

On the contrary, from the very beginning, his family appears in circumstances of vulnerability. Shortly after his birth, Joseph is warned in a dream to flee to Egypt because Herod intends to kill the child. Joseph gets up, takes the child and his mother, and leaves during the night (Matthew 2:13–15). After Herod's death, the family returns and settles in Nazareth (Matthew 2:19–23).

In other words, Jesus' childhood was marked from his earliest years by displacement, insecurity, and the need to flee a political threat.

The Gospel of Luke also portrays a humble family in the account of Jesus' presentation in the Temple. Mary and Joseph offer, in accordance with the Law, "a pair of turtledoves or two young pigeons" (Luke 2:22–24). This passage is significant because Leviticus 12:8 provided for this offering in the case of those who could not afford a lamb. It is not mathematical proof of Joseph and Mary's income, but it is consistent with the picture of a family of modest means.

Therefore, there is no basis in the Gospels for turning Jesus into an example of material prosperity.

On the contrary, when he is already an adult, Jesus declares:

"Foxes have dens and birds of the sky have nests, but the Son of Man has nowhere to rest his head."

Matthew 8:20; Luke 9:58.

This statement is particularly important because Jesus is describing the condition of those who follow him and, at the same time, his own condition as an itinerant preacher and pilgrim. This is not the language of someone concerned with presenting a life of luxury as a sign of divine approval.

This also helps us understand a statement made by Paul in 2 Corinthians 8:9:

"For you know the gracious act of our Lord Jesus Christ, that for your sake he became poor although he was rich, so that by his poverty you might become rich."

The principal meaning of this passage is theological: Paul is speaking about Christ's voluntary self-emptying and the grace manifested through him. Yet it also shows that the Christian message does not connect Christ's incarnation with the pursuit of material wealth. The movement described by the apostle is precisely one of self-emptying, not ostentation.

The same principle appears even more broadly in Philippians 2:5–8, when Paul describes Christ as the one who, existing in the form of God, took the form of a servant and humbled himself, becoming obedient unto death.

There is also a passage from the Old Testament that, for the Christian faith, is central to this question.

Isaiah writes:

“He was spurned and avoided by men, a man of suffering, knowing pain.”

Isaiah 53:3.

Isaiah 53 describes the so-called “Suffering Servant,” a figure whom early Christianity interpreted as referring prophetically to Jesus Christ. The New Testament itself applies the imagery of Isaiah 53 to Jesus in various contexts, including Matthew 8:16–17, Acts 8:30–35, and 1 Peter 2:22–25.

Therefore, when the biblical text calls the Servant “a man of suffering, knowing pain,” it is not presenting a Messiah whose mission would be to demonstrate that God's blessing necessarily manifests itself through wealth, comfort, and material success.

On the contrary, the trajectory of Jesus' life as presented in the Gospels passes through the humility of his birth, the flight to Egypt, a life without luxury, an itinerant ministry, rejection, persecution, and finally crucifixion.

This deserves particular attention when some contemporary versions of so-called prosperity theology use Jesus to support the idea that material wealth is a necessary consequence of faith or evidence that a particular person is being blessed by God.

An important distinction must be made.

Christianity does not teach that having money is a sin. The Bible presents faithful people who possessed material goods. The problem lies in turning wealth into automatic evidence of faith, spirituality, or divine approval.

Jesus himself warned against the idea that a person's life consists in the abundance of possessions (Luke 12:15). He also said that no one can serve both God and money (Matthew 6:24). And elsewhere, he warned of the dangers wealth can pose to spiritual life (Mark 10:17–27).

Therefore, claiming that Jesus lived a life of luxury and material wealth and then using him as a model of financial prosperity appears to be in tension with the portrait presented by the Gospels themselves.

Jesus was not born in a palace.

He did not grow up in an aristocratic family.

He is not portrayed surrounded by luxury.

He did not build his identity around material possessions.

He did not teach his disciples to measure God's blessing by the amount of money they accumulated.

His life presents precisely the opposite: human dignity does not depend on the amount of wealth a person possesses.

And this brings us back to the question of childhood.

Jesus was born into a humble family.

Moses was born into a family threatened by an order of extermination.

Neither chose the circumstances into which he was born.

And neither needed a materially perfect childhood for his life to have value, purpose, or dignity.

Moses and the Context We Cannot Ignore

And if we want to take this logic to its extreme, we could also remember Moses.

Imagine the scene as described by a contemporary influencer with no concern whatsoever for historical context:

“Guys, are you seeing this? His mother put her own baby in a basket and put the basket in the river! What is this? Poor planning? Neglect? Today this would probably even end up in court!”

“How could you not have a safe home in which to raise your child?”

“How can you put a baby in a basket and leave his fate in the hands of the river?”

“If you didn’t have the means to guarantee his safety and stability, why did you have a child?”

This is obviously an absurd interpretation once we know the context.

According to Exodus 1:8–22, Pharaoh had ordered that newborn Hebrew boys be killed. It was in this context that Moses was born.

The following chapter tells us that his mother, Jochebed, hid the child for three months. When she could no longer keep him hidden, she took a papyrus basket, coated it with bitumen and pitch, placed the baby inside, and set it among the reeds along the bank of the Nile. His sister stood at a distance to see what would happen (Exodus 2:1–4).

The text does not describe a mother who simply abandoned her child.

It describes a mother trying to preserve her child’s life in the face of a threat that was far beyond her control.

Pharaoh’s daughter found the child, took pity on him, and, through a series of providential events narrated in the text, the baby was initially cared for by his own mother (Exodus 2:5–10).

If we completely removed the context from the story, we could turn a desperate attempt at protection into an accusation of neglect.

And that is precisely the point.

It is very easy to judge a family when we know only the outcome but not the circumstances that led to it.

Today, someone might look at Moses and ask:

“But why couldn’t his parents provide him with a safe childhood?”

The answer would be simple: because the family was living through an extraordinary circumstance, determined by events that were completely beyond that mother’s control.

And this reminds us of a truth that remains valid thousands of years later: not every parent chooses the circumstances into which their children are born.

Some face poverty.

Others face war.

Others political or religious persecution.

Others illness, unemployment, economic crises, or natural disasters.

There are parents who have to flee their homes carrying their children in their arms. There are mothers who have to improvise simply to feed a child. There are families who have to leave almost everything they own behind in an attempt to preserve their lives.

To judge these people by the same standard we would use to evaluate someone who deliberately abandons or abuses a child would be profoundly unjust.

Of course, this does not mean romanticizing poverty or dangerous circumstances. Children need protection, food, housing, and security. Ideally, they should have all of these things.

But there is a difference between saying that a child deserves better conditions and saying that the parents are morally culpable for being unable to provide perfect conditions.

Moses did not choose to be born into that situation.

Jesus did not choose to be born into a humble family either.

And none of us chose the family, country, historical period, or economic circumstances into which we were born.

Perhaps that is why we should exercise a little more humility before turning every difficulty of childhood into an accusation against our parents.

Life has never given anyone a manual saying, “Only have children when absolutely everything is under control.”

If that were the rule, humanity would probably have disappeared thousands of years ago.

And, when you think about it, perhaps the truly remarkable thing is this: if Moses had been born in our time and his story were told by certain Internet commentators without any context, his mother might not be remembered as a woman who desperately tried to

save her son. Instead, she might be remembered as someone who “put her baby in a basket and threw him into the river.”

And someone would probably ask, with all the seriousness of a thirty-second video:

“Where is the parenting plan?”

One Final Reflection

Perhaps these two biblical stories teach us something that goes far beyond religion itself.

We cannot evaluate a childhood solely by the material possessions that were available.

We cannot automatically evaluate the quality of a family by the size of its house, the price of its clothes, the number of vacations it took, or the number of toys it owned.

Nor can we evaluate a family simply because it went through difficult circumstances.

Poverty can be the result of countless circumstances. Wealth can also conceal countless forms of suffering.

What matters is distinguishing a lack of resources from a lack of care.

Jesus was born in humble circumstances and, according to the Christian account, that did not diminish his dignity.

Moses was born into extremely dangerous circumstances, and his mother did everything within her power to protect him.

Therefore, perhaps we should abandon the idea that a childhood has to be perfect in order to be a good childhood.

Children need security, food, protection, education, affection, and care. But they also need adults to understand a fundamental truth: no one can control every circumstance of life.

Parents can do everything within their power and still face difficulties.

They can deeply love their children and be unable to buy what those children want.

They can provide emotional security while living in a modest home.

They can make mistakes without being abusers.

They can lack wealth and still provide things money cannot buy.

And perhaps this is one of the most important lessons we can draw from both the story of Jesus and the story of Moses:

a difficult life is not necessarily a loveless life, just as a comfortable life is not necessarily a well-cared-for life.

The real question is not whether a family managed to provide everything.

It is whether, within the circumstances it was given, it sought to care for those entrusted to its responsibility.

Because no one chooses all the cards they are dealt.

But within their possibilities, they can choose how they play them.